

THE GENERALS
(From left) BJP heavyweights Yogi Adityanath, Nitin Gadkari,Rajnath Singh, Amit Shah and others at the national executive in Delhi, Jan. 16

2,500 delegates from Tamil Nadu. In January, at his annual town hall with students, '*Pariksha pe charcha*', Modi highlighted the rich history of the Tamil language, calling it one of India's "big treasures" and a "source of pride". He even acknowledged that the language is the oldest in the world, a departure in a sense from the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh's position of Sanskrit being superior to any other language.

In Punjab, the party is using a different strategy, flooding the state unit with turncoats from the Congress and the Akali Dal. This includes Manjinder Singh Sirsa, former chief of the Delhi Sikh Gurdwara Management Committee (DSGMC), Kanwarpal Tohra, former Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee (SGPC) chief Gurcharan Singh Tohra's grandson, and Didar Singh Bhatti, a member of the SGPC. They have even made an *amritdhari* (baptised) Sikh, Iqbal Singh Lalpura, chief of the National Commission for Minorities and inducted him into the BJP's top decision-making body, the parliamentary board. How this will square with the party's traditional Hindu vote base in the state is uncertain at this point, especially since some of the recruits are of a persuasion that holds slain terrorist Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale a saint/ martyr. Even a year back, a leader professing such leanings would have been unthinkable in the BJP, but such are the exigencies of politics. In a recent reshuffle of the state unit, 11 of the 27 office-bearers came from the dominant Jat Sikh community.

Back again in the south, the party is in a muddle over whether or not to tie up with N. Chandrababu Naidu's Telugu Desam Party (TDP). In 2019, the Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy-led YSR Congress had swept the simultaneous Lok Sabha and Vidhan Sabha polls, crushing the TDP. More than the BJP, it's a desperate TDP that is pushing for an alliance now. Last August, Naidu had even met PM Modi after a gap of five long years. A tie-up will give the BJP some added leverage in neighbouring Telangana though there is one school of thought that believes the party should go it alone, play along with Jagan and reward him for his passive support of the NDA.

HELPING HANDS

The govt functionaries helping the party organisation win elections



AMIT SHAH
Union home minister
De facto COO of BJP's election machine



DHARMENDRA PRADHAN, *HRD minister*
Is well networked with younger BJP leaders in BJP, close to RSS leaders too. Led UP campaign



GAJENDRA SINGH SHEKHAWAT
Water resources minister
Has direct access to Modi, Shah, Nadda and RSS leaders. Anchoring party push in tough Punjab



MANSUKH MANDAVIYA
Health minister
Close associate of PM Modi. Stock has risen after Gujarat poll performance. Co-in-charge of the Karnataka polls



BHUPENDER YADAV
Environment minister
Go-to man for dialogue with dissidents, RSS leaders



YOGI ADITYANATH
Uttar Pradesh CM
Sought-after leader during poll campaigns. Evoking Hindutva sentiments in saffron robes, he is now seen as a tough administrator



PRAHLAD JOSHI
Parliamentary affairs minister
Anchored party campaign in Uttarakhand



HIMANTA BISWA SARMA, *Assam CM*
De facto head of Northeast operations. Trying to position himself as new icon of Hindutva



DEVENDRA FADNAVIS
Maharashtra deputy CM
Stock has risen after coup in Maharashtra. Anchored the sabotage in Congress's Goa unit as well. Has RSS backing